

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global overview with 2023 burden data (DALYs per 100,000)

Audience

Public health policy analysts and mental health program planners

Source

Our World in Data — Mental Health (Dattani, Rodés-Guirao, Ritchie, Roser, 2023)

Data source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025)

Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Ma

1 in 3

Women

will experience major depression in their lifetime

1 in 5

Men

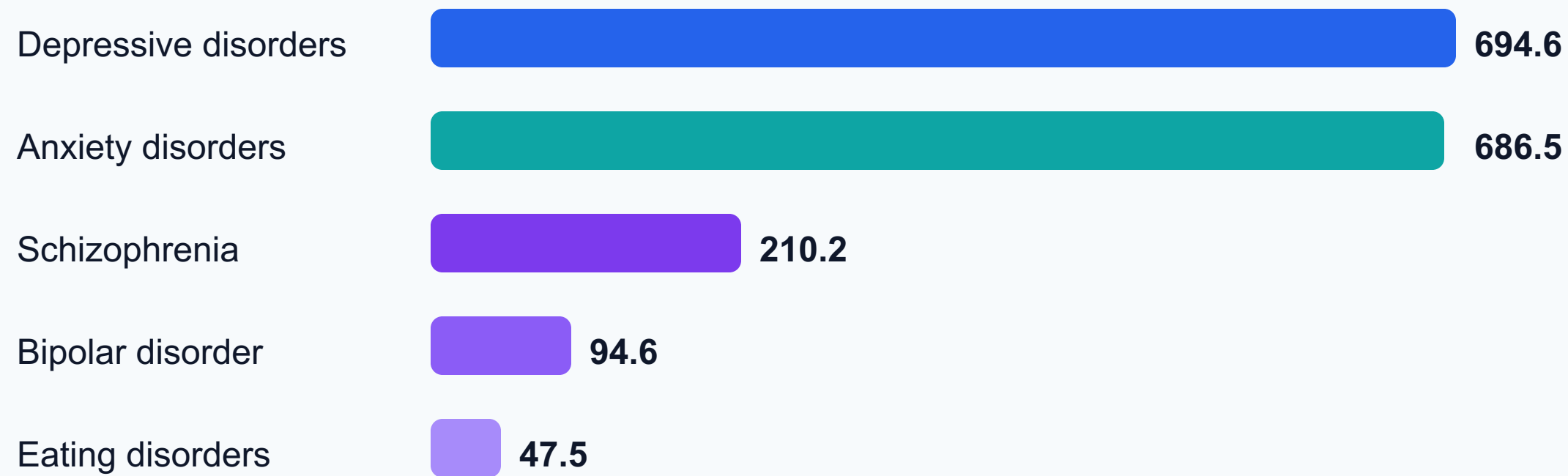
will experience major depression in their lifetime

Why this matters for policy

Mental health conditions include common disorders (depression, anxiety) and less common but severe conditions (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder). Large affected populations plus high disability create major health-system demand.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K P

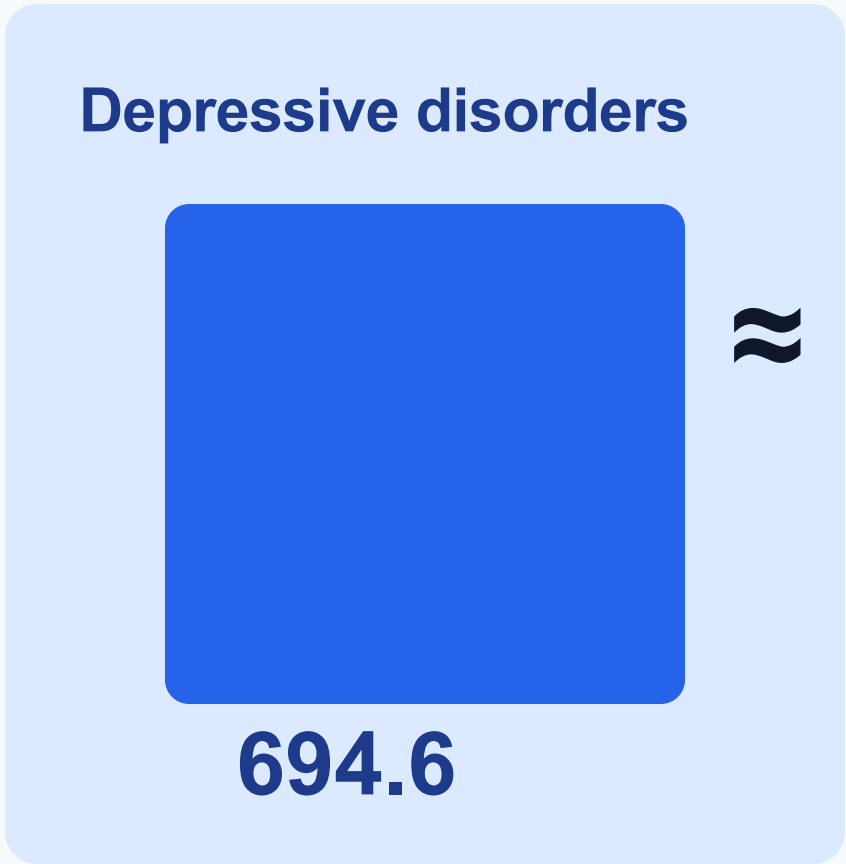
Burden of disease measured as DALYs per 100,000 people (World, 2023)



Key point

Depressive and anxiety disorders together account for roughly 80% of DALYs across these five categories.

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide



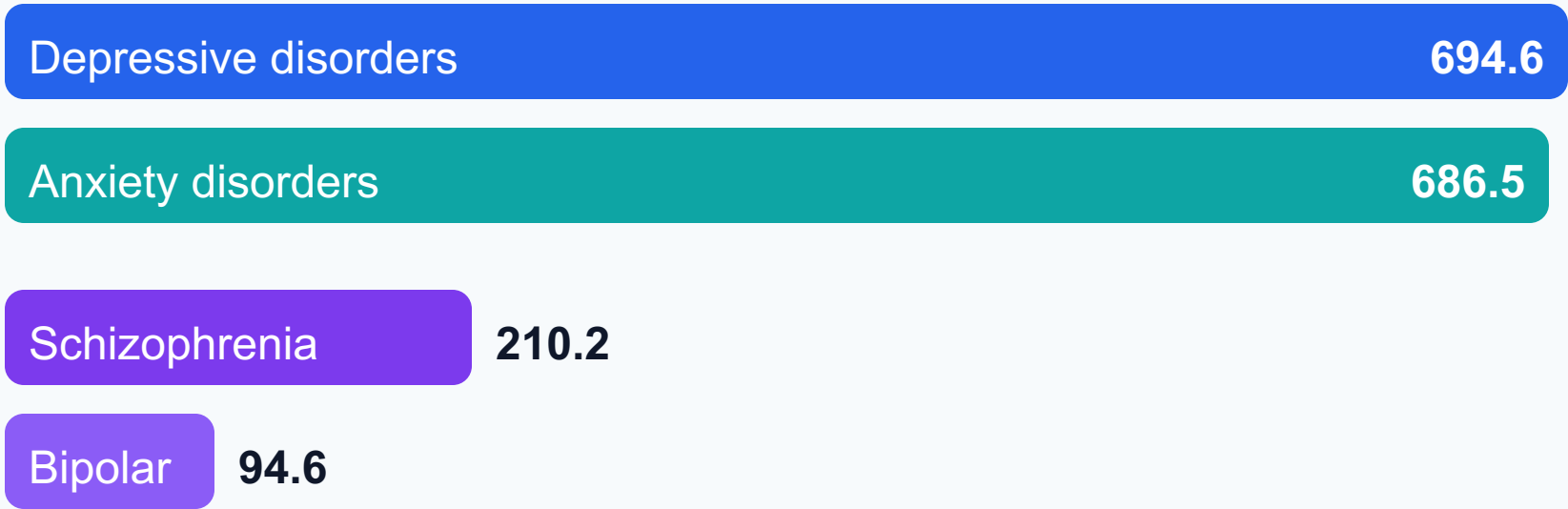
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Together these two categories represent roughly 80% of DALYs among the five mental illness groups shown

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individuals

DALYs per 100,000 (comparison)



Policy Interpretation

- Population DALYs are lower than depression/anxiety.
- Individual disability can be severe and long-term.
- Systems need specialized care alongside scaled common-care.

Lower prevalence does not imply low severity at the individual level.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable, but many people still do not receive adequate care.



Stigma

Discomfort disclosing symptoms



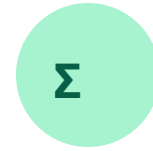
Access

Treatment is often lacking or



Quality

Even where care exists, it's



Underreporting

Hidden symptoms make treatment

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversation



Prescribed medication

Common in many higher-income se



Religious / spiritual ac

Prevalent coping approach in many



Talking to friends/family

A widely reported social-support mecha

Coping strategies vary widely across countries; policy responses should be culturally sensitive, not one-size

Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Tr

- Depression and anxiety are the dominant contributors to mental health DALYs.
- Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder have lower population burden but high individual severity.
- Treatment exists, yet access and quality remain inadequate in many settings.
- Stigma suppresses help-seeking and contributes to underreporting of true burden.
- Policy priority: scale evidence-based care for common disorders while sustaining specialized services.